

Considering Resistance in Economic Institutions

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- 2 Evaluating Economic Institutions
- 3 Framework for resistance at work
- 4 Considering categorical objections
- 5 Final thoughts

Section 1

Introduction

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- if we think things are really bad, we must be morally allowed to do more

Section 2

Evaluating Economic Institutions

Common Features

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- where something happens in these institutions that violates other people's rights
- as opposed to things happening in more narrowly political institutions

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 - Or Tom Malleon: „the current system of hierarchical work is deeply unjust“ (*After Occupy*, 28)
 - Or Isabelle Ferreras: “citizens, when they arrive at their jobs, become the subjects of a despotic corporate government“ (*Firms as Political Entities*, 3)

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 - Tom Malleson: “So what reforms should be pursued in order to help effect a transition to an economy characterized by significant workplace democracy? Increasing the strength of workers to bargain for increased voice at work requires strengthening unions and increasing workers’ ability to exit through an enhanced welfare system or, more profoundly, a basic income. Expanding the presence of worker co-ops requires help along three axes: legal support, financial support, and educational support.” (86)

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- often not considering who can pass them or how or under what conditions!

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 - Eric Posner and David Weisbach: "Climate change ranks among the most serious problems facing the world today." (*Climate Change Justice*, 1)
 - Stephen Gardiner: "Climate change is widely recognized as the greatest challenge currently facing humanity. For more than twenty-five years, major scientific reports have consistently argued that the threat is real and largely man-made, and delays in action likely to have serious negative consequences." (*Climate Ethics in a Dark and Dangerous Time*, 430)

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 - Posner & Weisbach: “What is to be done? A great deal remains unclear, but a few points are straightforward. First, the governments of the leading contributors, now and in the future, should adopt policies that reduce greenhouse gas emissions. [...] Second, whichever policies are chosen—taxes, cap and trade, or something else—governments around the world [...] will need to coordinate these policies, most likely through a treaty.” (2)

- Gardiner: “Ongoing political inertia surrounding climate action suggests that so far we are failing the ethical test posed by the perfect moral storm. In my view, a major root of the problem is institutional. While the institutions that are currently dominant [...] may be good at registering and promoting short-term and narrowly economic interests, we lack institutions that are effective in doing so for intergenerational and ecological concerns. Consequently, I propose that we develop the idea of, advocate for, and support the establishment of a global constitutional convention—akin to the American constitutional convention of 1787—directed toward future generations.” (436f.)

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 - Thomas Pogge: “My focus is then on the present situation, on the radical inequality between the bottom half of humankind, suffering severe poverty, and those in the top seventh, whose per capita share of the global product is 180 times greater than theirs [. . .]. This radical inequality and the continuous misery and death toll it engenders are foreseeably reproduced under the present global institutional order as we have shaped it. And most of it could be avoided, I hold, if this global order had been, or were to be, designed differently.” (*Severe Poverty as a Violation of Negative Duties*, 55)

- Leif Wenar: “We do fund human suffering when we make our everyday purchases, and our shopping today does incentivize injustice tomorrow. More, we have been connected to oppression and conflict, corruption and poverty, throughout our lives. As we will see, consumer spending for natural resources prolonged the life of the Soviet regime as well as apartheid in South Africa; it sustained both Pol Pot and Saddam Hussein in power; it helped pay for the genocide in Darfur; and it fired vicious conflicts in Angola and Sierra Leone.” (*Blood Oil*, XIX)

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 - Wenar: “This book hopes to present a persuasive case that we should decide to trade in accordance with our own deepest principles—instead of trading in violation of those principles, as we now do. Western countries should change their own rules of trade so as to respect the right of all peoples to take control over their own resources, and so to chart their own fates.”
(XXVIII)

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 - similar moves are available for climate justice and global justice

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 - action regarding claims of substantial injustice should look different than action regarding claims about prudence or taste

Section 3

Framework for resistance at work

A general thought about moral rights

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- under some proper restrictions

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 - Arridge and Lai & Lim on Ecotage

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 - not just stealing because you like money!

Section 4

Considering categorical objections

Work isn't so bad after all

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 - e.g. work isn't an important part of people's lives

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- many possibilities for structuring firms differently!
- or for working in a different job where you're not doing bad things to people

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 - 2 Democratic version: employees should try political activism before breaking the law

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- e.g. Finlay 2005 (132): “Necessity demands that agents choose that strategy for achieving the just cause that offers the best possible balance between morally relevant anticipated costs and morally relevant expected gains.”

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- consider empirical data on how easy or hard it is to do things politically

Other things first - the democratic version

- „In a democratic state, one should use institutional means wherever available in defending against injustice.”
- a kind of rule of law concern
- this is a complicated point
- requires a lot of the same „reasonable expectations“ considerations as the first point
- in the end: a difficult socio-historical judgement
- for example re: workplace democracy:
 - on the one hand: hundreds of years of worker activism
 - on the other hand: little current urgency about voice at work
- consider empirical data on how easy or hard it is to do things politically
- again: err on the side of those who are harmed!

Section 5

Final thoughts

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- mainly motivated by a concern for coherence between diagnoses and proposed solutions

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- most plausible seems to me the rule of law point

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- mainly motivated by a concern for coherence between diagnoses and proposed solutions
- most plausible seems to me the rule of law point
- liability point seems less concerning to me, although it might substantially shrink the range of plausible addressees

The end

Thank you for listening!

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